South Island self-drive: Christchurch to Queenstown, 6-14 March 2027

2027-03-06 → 2027-03-14 · 9 days · 2 travellers · Total 2089 km · longest day 5 h 46

Everything checked fits. 3 details still need confirming (see Open items).

Date	Route	km	Driving	Sunset	Overnight
Day 1 · Sat 6 Mar	Land in Christchurch, collect the car, sleep at the airport	0	0 min	20:09	Novotel Christchurch Airport
Day 2 · Sun 7 Mar	Over Arthur's Pass to the West Coast	311	4 h 23	20:13	Fitzherbert Court Motel (alternative: Hokitika's Kiwi Holiday Park and Motels, one-bedroom twin unit)
Day 3 · Mon 8 Mar	Glacier Country: Franz Josef and Fox glaciers	169	2 h 28	20:15	Heartland Hotel Fox Glacier
Day 4 · Tue 9 Mar	Lake Matheson, the Haast Pass, Wanaka and on to Queenstown	341	4 h 52	20:20	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside
Day 5 · Wed 10 Mar	Lindis Pass, Lake Pukaki and Aoraki / Mount Cook	397	5 h 46	20:10	Peppers Bluewater Resort (alternative: Mantra Lake Tekapo)
Day 6 · Thu 11 Mar	Mt John, then down to Queenstown	278	4 h 38	20:16	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside
Day 7 · Fri 12 Mar	The Milford Road to Milford Sound (no boat)	409	5 h 36	20:19	Distinction Luxmore Hotel Te Anau
Day 8 · Sat 13 Mar	Takahē in Te Anau, kiwi in Queenstown	176	2 h 27	20:13	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside
Day 9 · Sun 14 Mar	Return the car and fly	8	11 min	20:11	—

Day by day

Day 1 · Sat 6 Mar · Land in Christchurch, collect the car, sleep at the airport

depart 16:00 · 0 km · Driving 0 min · Sunset 20:09 · Overnight Novotel Christchurch Airport

Your flight lands at 14:30. Allow 60 to 90 minutes for immigration, biosecurity and the rental counter (biosecurity is strict: declare all food, hiking boots and outdoor gear). The hotel is a two-minute walk from the terminal, so there is no driving after a travel day. Keep snacks and water in the car for tomorrow: there is little on SH73 before Arthur's Pass village.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
16:00 depart	Christchurch Airport (CHC)		Pick up the one-way rental at the airport desk after clearing customs.
16:00	Novotel Christchurch Airport	0 km 0 min	Novotel Christchurch Airport has 24-hour reception and a restaurant. Park the rental car here overnight (parking is extra).

Tips

• Ask the rental desk to confirm in writing that the one-way drop-off at Queenstown Airport on 14 March is included, and what the one-way fee is.

• Check the car's fuel type and range, and whether the contract excludes any roads (the unsealed road beyond the Tasman Glacier car park is commonly excluded).

• Download offline maps for the whole South Island tonight: much of SH6 and SH94 has no mobile signal.

Day 2 · Sun 7 Mar · Over Arthur's Pass to the West Coast

depart 07:30 · 311 km · Driving 4 h 23 · Sunset 20:13 · Overnight Fitzherbert Court Motel (alternative: Hokitika's Kiwi Holiday Park and Motels, one-bedroom twin unit)

The first full driving day crosses the Southern Alps on SH73 through Arthur's Pass National Park, then drops to the West Coast. Two short walks break up the drive: the limestone boulders of Kura Tāwhiti and the 131 m Devils Punchbowl waterfall. In the afternoon you continue to the turquoise Hokitika Gorge before settling in Hokitika.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:30 depart	Novotel Christchurch Airport		
08:54–09:34	Kura Tāwhiti Castle Hill	89 km 1 h 17	Kura Tāwhiti (Castle Hill) is a field of huge limestone boulders beside SH73, of great cultural significance to Ngāi Tahu. Walk in among the rocks on the formed path for 30 to 40 minutes. Stay on the track and don't climb on the rocks unless you are a climber. Free.
10:24–11:34	Devils Punchbowl Falls car park, Arthur's Pass	54 km 45 min	A 1 hour return walk (DOC) through beech forest to a 131 m waterfall, starting at the north end of Arthur's Pass village. The track has steps and is steep in places but well formed. Free; always open.
11:35–12:15	Arthur's Pass village	0 km 1 min	Lunch in Arthur's Pass village; buy food here. There is a DOC visitor centre for track and road updates.
14:16–15:26	Hokitika Gorge car park	134 km 1 h 50	The walk from the car park to the viewing platform and swing bridge over the turquoise gorge takes about 10 minutes each way; the full loop back via the upper bridge is about 1 hour (DOC). Swimming is not advised. The car park is busy from November to April, so arrive mid-afternoon rather than at midday. Free.
15:59	Hokitika	34 km 30 min	Hokitika is a small heritage town with supermarkets and fuel. Fill the tank here for tomorrow.

Tips

• Kea (alpine parrots) are common at Arthur's Pass: never feed them, and don't leave anything loose on the car.

• Buy lunch in Arthur's Pass village; there is little else on SH73.

• Hokitika Gorge has no mobile coverage beyond the car park and lots of sandflies: bring insect repellent.

Day 3 · Mon 8 Mar · Glacier Country: Franz Josef and Fox glaciers

depart 08:00 · 169 km · Driving 2 h 28 · Sunset 20:15 · Overnight Heartland Hotel Fox Glacier

South along SH6 into Westland Tai Poutini National Park for a two-glacier day. Walk up the valley to view the Franz Josef Glacier, see kiwi and penguins at the West Coast Wildlife Centre, then walk the Fox Glacier South Side track to viewpoints of the Fox Glacier. A short driving day leaves time for both walks.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:00 depart	Hokitika		
10:03–11:43	Franz Josef Glacier walk car park	138 km 1 h 52	The Franz Josef Glacier / Kā Roimata o Hine Hukatere walk is about 1.5 hours return over 5.4 km along the river-bed to a viewpoint of the glacier (newzealand.com). Stay behind the barriers; the valley has rockfall and flood risk. Free; parking fees may apply (a DOC paid-parking pilot ran here until June 2026).
11:53–13:08	West Coast Wildlife Centre, Franz Josef	5 km 9 min	The West Coast Wildlife Centre shows live kiwi in a nocturnal house during the day, and in October 2025 added a penguin encounter. Allow an hour; tickets are valid 48 hours. Adult entry about NZ$50 to 65 on reseller sites; the 40-minute Backstage Pass tour has very limited places, so book that ahead if you want it. Lunch in Franz Josef village afterwards.
13:36–15:21	Fox Glacier South Side Walk car park	24 km 26 min	The Fox Glacier South Side Walk starts 2 km south of the township, across the Fox River bridge. It is about 40 minutes to the first glacier viewpoint and 10 minutes more to the final one (DOC), so allow 1 h 45 min return. The viewpoints are hundreds of metres from the ice; do not go past the final viewpoint (flood hazard). Free.
15:22	Fox Glacier township	1 km 1 min	Fox Glacier township is small: eat early, as small-town kitchens often close around 20:00. Refuel here.

Tips

- Check the Glacier Country daily access update in the morning: the glacier walk can close after heavy rain or ice collapse.
- Lake Matheson is saved for first thing tomorrow, when the air is usually stillest and the reflections are best.
- Fuel up in Fox Glacier tonight: the next fuel is at Haast, 120 km south.

Day 4 · Tue 9 Mar · Lake Matheson, the Haast Pass, Wanaka and on to Queenstown

depart 07:40 · 341 km · Driving 4 h 52 · Sunset 20:20 · Overnight Novotel Queenstown Lakeside

Start at Lake Matheson in the still morning air for the mirror reflection of Aoraki/Mount Cook and Mount Tasman. Then SH6 follows the wild coast to Haast, then climbs the Haast Pass (Tioripatea) through Mount Aspiring National Park. The day is a string of short stops: a coastal lookout, two waterfalls and the glacier-blue Blue Pools, before the road opens out beside Lakes Wanaka and Hāwea. After a lakefront stop in Wanaka you cross to Queenstown for the second Accor night of the trip.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:40 depart	Fox Glacier township		
07:47–09:27	Lake Matheson car park	5 km 7 min	The Lake Matheson / Te Ara Kairaumati loop is 2.6 km and about 1.5 hours (DOC blog; newzealand.com), through podocarp forest to the reflection viewpoints. Easy and flat. Reflections need still air, which is most likely early in the morning. The café at the car park opens for breakfast. Free.
10:53–11:08	Knights Point lookout	98 km 1 h 18	A roadside coastal lookout over the Tasman Sea with toilets and a picnic area (DOC). A 15-minute stop to stretch your legs. No walk to the beach is needed.
11:32–11:52	Haast township (fuel)	28 km 22 min	Last fuel before Makarora/Wanaka; toilets and food. Fill up even if half full.
12:35–12:50	Thunder Creek Falls	52 km 39 min	Thunder Creek Falls drops 96 m; a few minutes' walk from the road through forest (DOC). Free.
12:53–13:08	Fantail Falls	4 km 3 min	Fantail Falls fans out over a rock face into the Haast River; a short walk from the road (DOC lists the Haast Pass waterfalls at 5 to 25 minutes return).
13:19–14:29	Blue Pools car park	13 km 10 min	The Blue Pools Track is 3 km and 1 hour return on a flat path (DOC) to swing bridges above clear blue pools where the Blue River meets the Makarora. The track reopened on 31 May 2025 after bridge rebuilds. Swimming isn't recommended. Free.
15:31–16:01	Wanaka lakefront	72 km 56 min	Stretch your legs on the Wanaka lakefront at the south end of Lake Wanaka. The route on to Queenstown is the Crown Range road via Cardrona: sealed but steep, high and winding, so take it slowly. The alternative via Cromwell is about 45 km longer.
17:26	Tāhuna Queenstown	69 km 1 h 17	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside, first of three nights in Queenstown (not consecutive).

Tips

• Check NZTA highway information for SH6 before leaving Fox: the Haast Pass is closed by slips and rockfall from time to time (see the backup plan).

• Sandflies are fierce at every Haast Pass stop; repellent on before you get out.

• Blue Pools swing bridges have a limit on how many people can be on them at once; expect a short wait.

• Prefer less driving? Sleep in Wanaka instead (Oakridge Resort Lake Wanaka, two single beds on request). That saves about 120 km over today and tomorrow but gives up one Accor night; this version was also checked and works.

Day 5 · Wed 10 Mar · Lindis Pass, Lake Pukaki and Aoraki / Mount Cook

depart 07:45 · 397 km · Driving 5 h 46 · Sunset 20:10 · Overnight Peppers Bluewater Resort (alternative: Mantra Lake Tekapo)

The biggest mountain day, and the longest drive. Leave Queenstown through Cromwell, cross the tussock of the Lindis Pass into the Mackenzie Basin, follow turquoise Lake Pukaki to the foot of Aoraki/Mount Cook, New Zealand's highest peak, and see two glaciers on short walks. Finish in Lake Tekapo for its famously dark night sky.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:45 depart	Tāhuna Queenstown		
08:42–08:57	Cromwell	61 km 52 min	Coffee and toilet stop in Cromwell after the first hour; you can also refuel here.
10:15–10:30	Lindis Pass summit	80 km 1 h 11	The Lindis Pass on SH8 crosses golden tussock between Otago and the Mackenzie Basin. Pull into the summit lay-by for a photo stop.
11:45–12:00	Lake Pukaki shore, SH8	74 km 1 h 08	Stop on the shore of Lake Pukaki on SH8 for the view up the lake to Aoraki/Mount Cook. On a clear morning this is one of the great views of the trip.
12:51–13:36	Aoraki / Mount Cook village	58 km 47 min	Early lunch in Aoraki/Mount Cook village before the walks; buy food here (there are only a few places to eat, and prices are high). The DOC visitor centre has the latest track updates.
13:43–15:23	White Horse Hill car park (Hooker Valley Track)	3 km 6 min	Walk the Hooker Valley Track from White Horse Hill car park to the second swing bridge (about 45 minutes each way, DOC) with views up the valley to Aoraki/Mount Cook. A new swing bridge on the track opened in July 2026. Paid parking by card. Turn around at the second bridge to stay inside your 2-hour walking limit.
15:38–16:38	Tasman Glacier car park (Blue Lakes and Tasman Glacier View)	10 km 14 min	From the Tasman Valley car park, climb about 300 steps to the Tasman Glacier View, overlooking the Tasman Glacier and its terminal lake, with a side trip to the Blue Lakes; 40 to 60 minutes return. Don't drive past the car park: the 4WD track beyond is excluded by most rental contracts.
18:15	Takapō Lake Tekapo	110 km 1 h 28	Lake Tekapo has fuel, a supermarket and restaurants along the lakefront.

Tips

• The full Hooker Valley Track is 3 hours return, longer than your 2-hour limit, so the plan walks to the second swing bridge and back (about 1.5 hours), which still gives you the swing bridges and the view up the valley to Aoraki/Mount Cook.

• White Horse Hill parking is paid by card only (NZ$2.50 per half hour or NZ$25 a day).

• Clear evening? Step outside after 21:30 in Tekapo: no tour is needed to see the Milky Way.

Day 6 · Thu 11 Mar · Mt John, then down to Queenstown

depart 09:00 · 278 km · Driving 4 h 38 · Sunset 20:16 · Overnight Novotel Queenstown Lakeside

Drive up Mt John first thing for a 360-degree view over Lake Tekapo and the Mackenzie Basin, then head south over the Lindis Pass, past Cromwell and through the Kawarau Gorge to Queenstown. Finish on the Skyline Gondola for the classic view over Lake Wakatipu and The Remarkables.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:00 depart	Takapō Lake Tekapo		
09:29–10:44	Mt John summit (Astro Café)	10 km 27 min	Drive the private road to the Mt John summit (road open 09:00 to 16:00, NZ$14 per car paid at the gate). Take in the view from the Astro Café terrace and walk part of the 30 to 45 minute summit circuit. Easy.
11:48–12:03	Lake Pukaki shore, SH8	52 km 58 min	Lake Pukaki again, now southbound, often with the morning cloud gone from Aoraki/Mount Cook: a 15-minute photo and stretch stop.
13:18–13:33	Lindis Pass summit	74 km 1 h 08	Second crossing of the Lindis Pass, southbound: a 15-minute break on the long stretch to Cromwell.
14:52–15:37	Cromwell	80 km 1 h 12	Late lunch and fuel in Cromwell. If you're hungry earlier, pick up food in Twizel as you drive through around 12:15.
16:34–18:04	Skyline Gondola base, Queenstown	61 km 52 min	The Skyline Gondola climbs to Bob's Peak for the best view over Queenstown, Lake Wakatipu and The Remarkables. A gondola-only ticket is about NZ$45 on reseller sites; book online for the day. Hours vary by season, so check the opening-hours page. The luge at the top is optional.
18:05	Tāhuna Queenstown	1 km 1 min	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside is on the lakefront at Earl Street and Marine Parade, a short walk to the gondola and town.

Tips

- The Mt John road opens at 09:00 and closes at 16:00; the NZ$14 toll is paid at the gate by card.
- Lunch is late today (Cromwell, about 15:00): have a big breakfast or buy snacks in Twizel as you pass.
- Queenstown parking is expensive and limited; leave the car at the hotel and walk to the gondola.

Day 7 · Fri 12 Mar · The Milford Road to Milford Sound (no boat)

depart 07:50 · 409 km · Driving 5 h 36 · Sunset 20:19 · Overnight Distinction Luxmore Hotel Te Anau

A long day but one of the most spectacular roads in the world: through Te Anau, up the Eglinton Valley past the Mirror Lakes, through the Homer Tunnel and down to Milford Sound (Piopiotahi). You stay on land: walk the foreshore for the classic view of Mitre Peak, then drive back to Te Anau for the night.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
07:50 depart	Tāhuna Queenstown		
08:36–08:51	Kingston (south end of Lake Wakatipu)	48 km 42 min	15-minute stretch and toilet stop at the south end of Lake Wakatipu.
10:39–10:59	Te Anau	126 km 1 h 38	Refuel and buy lunch in Te Anau before the Milford Road.
11:46–12:01	Mirror Lakes	56 km 43 min	A boardwalk of about 10 minutes beside small lakes that reflect the mountains on a still day (DOC Milford Highway brochure). Free.
12:50–13:15	The Chasm	53 km 45 min	A 20-minute return forest walk to where the river has carved holes and bowls in the rock (DOC). Free.
13:26–14:26	Piopiotahi Milford Sound foreshore	9 km 10 min	Walk the short foreshore track from the car park for the view of Mitre Peak and the fiord. No boat is needed for this view. Parking at Milford Sound has been charged at about NZ$10 an hour; DOC is planning bookable parking and a charge for international visitors, but neither was confirmed for March 2027 when this plan was written.
16:14	Te Anau	118 km 1 h 38	Te Anau is a lakeside town with supermarkets, fuel and restaurants.

Tips

- Fill the tank in Te Anau: there is no fuel on the 120 km Milford Road.
- Pack lunch and water in Te Anau; Milford Sound has only limited supplies.
- The Homer Tunnel is single-lane with traffic lights, so expect a wait in each direction; allow for it on the way back.

Day 8 · Sat 13 Mar · Takahē in Te Anau, kiwi in Queenstown

depart 09:00 · 176 km · Driving 2 h 27 · Sunset 20:13 · Overnight Novotel Queenstown Lakeside

An easier last full day. See the rare takahē at the free Te Anau Bird Sanctuary, drive back to Queenstown along Lake Wakatipu, and visit Kiwi Park for kiwi up close. Pack in the evening and set an alarm for tomorrow's early car return.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
09:00 depart	Te Anau		
09:04–09:49	Punanga Manu o Te Anau / Te Anau Bird Sanctuary	2 km 4 min	Punanga Manu o Te Anau / Te Anau Bird Sanctuary is free and open in daylight hours (DOC), with takahē, a rare flightless bird once thought extinct. DOC has recently reduced the number of birds and changed tours, so check at the Fiordland National Park Visitor Centre if you want a guided visit. Donations welcome.
11:38–11:53	Kingston (south end of Lake Wakatipu)	126 km 1 h 39	15-minute stretch and toilet stop at the south end of Lake Wakatipu.
12:40–13:55	Kiwi Park Queenstown	48 km 43 min	Kiwi Park Queenstown shows kiwi up close in a nocturnal house, alongside other native birds. Summer hours run to 18:30 (last entry 17:45). Adult tickets about NZ$54 to 68 on Bookme; online early or late-entry tickets can be cheaper.
13:56	Tāhuna Queenstown	1 km 1 min	Third night at Novotel Queenstown Lakeside.

Tips

- If the Milford Road was closed yesterday, use today as the backup Milford day (see the backup plan) and skip Kiwi Park.
- Refuel in Queenstown or Frankton this evening if the rental requires a full tank on return.
- Clean walking boots and finish fresh food before you fly: biosecurity rules apply at most destinations.

Day 9 · Sun 14 Mar · Return the car and fly

depart 08:00 · 8 km · Driving 11 min · Sunset 20:11

No sightseeing today. Drive 10 minutes to Queenstown Airport, refuel nearby if the rental requires it, return the car and check in for the 11:00 flight.

Time	Place	Drive here	Notes
08:00 depart	Tāhuna Queenstown		
08:12	Queenstown Airport (ZQN)	8 km 11 min	Return the rental car at Queenstown Airport, then check in for the 11:00 flight.

Tips

• Aim to have the car returned by 08:45, which leaves two hours before an international departure.

• Photograph the car's fuel gauge and odometer at return.

Bookings and tickets

Book by	Item	Date	Status	Ref	Terms / notes
2026-11-30	One-way rental car, Christchurch Airport 6 Mar ~15:30 to Queenstown Airport 14 Mar 09:00, one driver, free cancellation	2027-03-06	not booked		Compare quotes including the one-way fee; book a free-cancellation rate now, as early March is still peak season.
2026-12-15	Novotel Christchurch Airport, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-06	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/city/hotels-christchurch-v5065.html
2026-12-15	Hokitika motel, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-07	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://www.fitzherbertcourt.co.nz/
2026-12-15	Heartland Hotel Fox Glacier, 1 night, Standard Twin	2027-03-08	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://www.scenichotelgroup.co.nz/fox-glacier/heartland-hotel-fox-glacier/
2026-12-15	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside, 1 night, two double beds	2027-03-09	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://all.accor.com/hotel/5308/index.en.shtml
2026-12-15	Peppers Bluewater Resort (or Mantra Lake Tekapo), 1 night, twin	2027-03-10	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://all.accor.com/gb/region/hotels-south-island-new-zealand-re14.shtml
2026-12-15	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside, 1 night, two double beds	2027-03-11	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://all.accor.com/hotel/5308/index.en.shtml
2026-12-15	Distinction Luxmore Hotel Te Anau, 1 night, two beds	2027-03-12	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://www.distinctionhotels.co.nz/hotel-luxmore
2026-12-15	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside, 1 night, two double beds	2027-03-13	not booked		Free-cancellation rate; book early because early March is still high season in Queenstown and Lake Tekapo · https://all.accor.com/hotel/5308/index.en.shtml
2027-02-22	West Coast Wildlife Centre entry (optional Backstage Pass tour, limited places)	2027-03-08	not booked		https://www.newzealand.com/nz/plan/business/west-coast-wildlife-centre-2/
2027-03-04	Skyline Queenstown gondola, 2 adults, late afternoon 11 Mar	2027-03-11	not booked		https://queenstown.skyline.co.nz/
2027-03-06	Kiwi Park Queenstown, 2 adults, 13 Mar	2027-03-13	not booked		https://www.bookme.co.nz/things-to-do/queenstown/activity/kiwi-park-queenstown-real-life-up-close-kiwi-viewing/264

Book by	Item	Date	Status	Ref	Terms / notes
	White Horse Hill car park (Hooker Valley), pay on arrival by card	2027-03-10	buy on site		https://www.doc.govt.nz/hooker-valley-track
	Mt John road toll NZ$14 per car	2027-03-11	buy on site		https://www.darkskyproject.co.nz/eat/astro-cafe/

Hotels

Date	Hotel	Brand	Room	Cost	Status	Terms / notes
2027-03-06	Novotel Christchurch Airport	Accor	Two beds (request)		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/a/en/destination/city/hotels-christchurch-v5065.html
2027-03-07	Fitzherbert Court Motel (alternative: Hokitika's Kiwi Holiday Park and Motels, one-bedroom twin unit)	—	Two beds (request)		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://www.fitzherbertcourt.co.nz/
2027-03-08	Heartland Hotel Fox Glacier	—	Standard Twin		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://www.scenichotelgroup.co.nz/fox-glacier/heartland-hotel-fox-glacier/
2027-03-09	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	Accor	Standard Room, two double beds		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/hotel/5308/index.en.shtml
2027-03-10	Peppers Bluewater Resort (alternative: Mantra Lake Tekapo)	Accor	Two beds (request)		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/gb/region/hotels-south-island-new-zealand-re14.shtml
2027-03-11	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	Accor	Standard Room, two double beds		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/hotel/5308/index.en.shtml
2027-03-12	Distinction Luxmore Hotel Te Anau	—	Two beds (request)		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://www.distinctionhotels.co.nz/hotel-luxmore
2027-03-13	Novotel Queenstown Lakeside	Accor	Standard Room, two double beds		not booked	Book a free-cancellation rate · https://all.accor.com/hotel/5308/index.en.shtml

Open items

Your requirements

• [met] At most 500 km in any day

• [met] Never drive after dark (checked against sunset with a 30-minute margin)

• [met] No boats or ferries of any kind (seasickness)

• [met] No ferries (part of the no-boat rule)

• [met] No beaches

• [met] No walks longer than about 2 hours

• [met] No sightseeing on 14 March, just return the car and fly

• [to confirm] Hotel budget up to NZ$300 per night

• [met] Arrive at Queenstown Airport in time for the 11:00 flight

Backup plans

• SH6 Haast Pass closed by a slip or rockfall before the trip (it is the only road from the West Coast to Wanaka) (decide by 2027-03-05): NZTA highway information (journeys.nzta.govt.nz) shows SH6 Haast Pass closed or under scheduled closures · Switch to plan B (checked like the main plan; day-by-day outline at the end of this section): Christchurch, Lake Tekapo, Aoraki/Mount Cook and Wanaka first, then the Haast Pass waterfalls and Blue Pools as an out-and-back from Wanaka, then

Queenstown, Te Anau and Milford Sound. The West Coast is dropped. Keep the West Coast hotels on free-cancellation rates until this date. · https://nzta.govt.nz/media-releases/haast-pass-closure-due-to-large-rockfall-at-clarke-bluff-sh6-highway-closed-all-day-tuesday-next-update-midday-wednesday/

• SH6 closes while you are on the West Coast (8-9 March) (decide by 2027-03-09): Closure notice on the morning of 9 March before leaving Fox Glacier · Plan C: stay a second night in Fox Glacier and wait (closures often lift within a day or two). When the road reopens, drive the 9 March route to Queenstown, then continue from 11 March as planned but without Aoraki/Mount Cook and Lake Tekapo (cancel the Tekapo night and spend 11 March in Queenstown). A detour north via Arthur's Pass and back south on SH8 is far over the 500 km daily limit, so it is not an option. · https://nzta.govt.nz/media-releases/haast-pass-sh6-remaining-closed-only-direct-link-west-coast-with-otago-next-update-monday

• SH94 Milford Road closed on 12 March (rockfall, flooding) (decide by 2027-03-11): Milford Road status on NZTA highway information on the evening of 11 March · Swap the days: on 12 March drive Queenstown to Te Anau (Bird Sanctuary, lakefront). On 13 March drive Te Anau, Milford Sound and back, then on to Queenstown (about 410 km, within the 500 km limit); skip Kiwi Park. · https://www.journeys.nzta.govt.nz/traffic-bulletins/update-8-january-2026-later-start-for-sh94-roadworks

• Hotel prices: none of the eight nights has a confirmed price yet (Accor and the other hotels show rates only for a live search). Check each against your NZ$300 limit when you book. Novotel Queenstown Lakeside (3 nights) and Lake Tekapo are the most likely to go over in early March; Accor's other Queenstown hotels (Mantra The Point, Peppers Beacon) are the fallback for the brand.

• One-way rental fee: not yet quoted. Get two or three quotes for Christchurch Airport to Queenstown Airport, 6 to 14 March, including the one-way fee and excess, before booking.

• Two beds: Fitzherbert Court Motel, Heartland Hotel Fox Glacier, Distinction Luxmore and Peppers Bluewater have twin or two-bed rooms only in some room types. Put "two separate beds" in each booking and get it confirmed.

• Skyline Gondola: 2027 hours and price not confirmed (about NZ$45 per adult on reseller sites). Check the Skyline site before booking.

• Milford Sound charges: DOC is planning a charge of about NZ$100 for international visitors and bookable parking. Neither had a start date in August 2026; check DOC's Milford Opportunities news in February 2027.

• Glacier walks: the Franz Josef and Fox Glacier South Side walks close after heavy rain or rockfall. Check the Glacier Country daily access update on the morning of 8 March; if a walk is closed, spend longer at the West Coast Wildlife Centre and do Lake Matheson that afternoon as well.

• Te Anau Bird Sanctuary: DOC has reduced the birds and changed tours; ask at the Fiordland National Park Visitor Centre in Te Anau on the evening of 12 March.

• Flight on 14 March: the plan assumes an international departure, so the car is back by 09:00, two hours before the flight. If it is a domestic flight you can leave the hotel later.

• Hokitika: the motel's latest check-in time isn't published; you arrive about 16:00, so this should not matter.

• Fewer kilometres (checked): sleep in Wanaka on 9 March (Oakridge Resort) instead of Queenstown. Days 4 and 5 shrink from 341 and 397 km to 272 and 340 km, but you have 4 Accor nights instead of 5.

• More Accor nights was possible only on paper: 6 Accor nights needs a 451 km first full day straight to Franz Josef and a nearly empty second day in Lake Tekapo, which loses the West Coast evening and sightseeing time. Not recommended.

• Plan B if the Haast Pass is closed before you fly (checked: all days within 500 km and before dark, 5 Accor nights): 6 Mar Novotel Christchurch Airport. 7 Mar via Geraldine to Lake Tekapo and Mt John, 242 km. 8 Mar Lake Pukaki, Hooker Valley and Tasman Glacier, then over the Lindis Pass to Wanaka, 335 km. 9 Mar out and back from Wanaka to Blue Pools, Fantail and Thunder Creek Falls, 178 km. 10 Mar Wanaka to Queenstown, Skyline Gondola and Kiwi Park, 70 km. 11 Mar Milford Sound day, night in Te Anau, 409 km. 12 Mar Bird Sanctuary and back to Queenstown, 176 km. 13 Mar spare day in Queenstown. 14 Mar return the car and fly.

Before you go

Checklist

• Get a written one-way rental quote (Christchurch Airport to Queenstown Airport) that includes the one-way fee, and check that the desk is open for a 14:30 landing. Book with free cancellation.

• Only one of you drives: make sure that driver is the main driver on the contract, with a credit card in their name. Their full Australian licence (in English) is valid in New Zealand.

• Ask the rental company which roads are excluded (typically the 4WD track beyond the Tasman Glacier car park) and what the excess is; consider reducing the excess.

• Book all eight hotels on free-cancellation rates and ask each one for two separate beds. Accor nights: Christchurch, Lake Tekapo and three nights in Queenstown (9, 11 and 13 March), so 5 of 8 nights. Enter your ALL number.

• Confirm each hotel rate against your NZ$300 budget. Queenstown and Lake Tekapo are the most likely to go over in early March.

• Check travel insurance covers a rental car excess and the whole trip in New Zealand.

• In the week before you fly: check NZTA highway information for SH6 Haast Pass, SH73 Arthur's Pass, SH80 Mount Cook and SH94 Milford Road, and DOC alerts for the walks.

• Check that New Zealand's entry requirements for your passports are met (not covered by this plan).

• Download offline maps and save this PDF on both phones; there is no signal on long stretches of SH6 and SH94.

• Emergency number in New Zealand: 111. Save the rental company's breakdown line.

Packing

• Insect repellent (sandflies at Hokitika Gorge, Haast Pass, Blue Pools and Milford Sound).

• Rain jacket and a warm layer: the West Coast is very wet, and Aoraki/Mount Cook and the Milford Road can be cold even in March.

• Walking shoes with grip for wet tracks and steps (Devils Punchbowl, Tasman Glacier View).

• Sunscreen, sunglasses and a hat: UV is strong in the Mackenzie Basin.

• A cool bag and refillable water bottles for the picnic lunch on the Milford Road day.

• Car phone charger and mount; a payment card that works at unattended fuel pumps.

• Motion-sickness tablets if anyone gets carsick: Arthur's Pass, Haast Pass and the Milford Road are winding.

• Clean boots before arrival: NZ biosecurity inspects outdoor gear, and all food must be declared.

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